

ber (MAC address) and IP address, and can combine that information with surfing habits and correlate it with any personal information provided during a 'free' software download or when a file attachment was opened. This information can then be traded with affiliate advertisers, building a complex dossier on individual users and what they like to do on the Internet.

Other programs are simple, 'useful' applications such as clocks, calendars, or mouse pointers, which are attractive bait for downloading spyware.

Although similar, adware is distinguished from spyware by the fact that, when downloading adware, the user is first given an opportunity to agree to its being placed on his or her computer. The explanation of an adware program and what it will do is often buried in a long, complex EULA that many users simply scroll through and accept without reading completely. In practice, adware acts as spyware. Both may trigger the display of pop-up or banner advertisements, and both may gather and transmit information from the user's computer.

How Spyware And Adware Can Be Acquired

- **When users unknowingly give their permission while downloading or installing applications:** Before installing most software programs, users are required to read and sign an End User License Agreement. But EULAs are long, confusing, and sometimes even deceptive. From a legal standpoint, everything may be duly disclosed in the EULA, but EULAs are often so long and complex that many users just click through them, never stopping to read them closely.
- Another method bypasses the security settings altogether by exploiting a bug in Internet Explorer versions 4 and 5. These versions allow Web scripts to gain access to a hard drive by overflowing the browser with data. Malicious Webmasters use this exploit to install spyware or modify the way the browser works.
- By simply visiting certain Web sites: Some spyware is secretly downloaded when a user launches a program acquired from a Web site. For example, a pop-up may notify the user that a spe-